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AI



Cognition, maker of the
AI coding agent Devin,
acquires Windsurf

[Cognition](#), the startup behind the viral [AI coding agent Devin](#), announced in a [blog post](#) on Monday that it has signed a definitive agreement to acquire [AI coding startup Windsurf](#).

The announcement comes just days after [Google](#) [hired away Windsurf's CEO](#) Varun Mohan, co-founder Douglas Chen, and research leaders in a \$2.4 billion reverse-acquire that left much of the startup's 250-person team behind. Google's deal occurred just hours after OpenAI's \$3 billion offer to acquire Windsurf expired, clearing the way for the AI coding startup to explore other options.

IMAGE CREDITS: COGNITION

The frenzy around Windsurf represents a new peak in the wild race to develop AI coding tools — specifically, the AI-powered integrated development environments (IDEs) that Cursor and Windsurf offer. In recent months, the businesses around AI-powered IDEs have skyrocketed, pushing Cursor's annualized recurring revenue (ARR) to \$500 million. While Windsurf's business is smaller than Cursor's, it has achieved impressive growth in the last year, garnering interest from several larger companies.

"The last 72 hours have been the wildest rollercoaster ride of my career," said Jeff Wang, Windsurf's former head of business, who was made interim CEO of the startup days ago after Google hired the startup's leaders, in a [post](#) on LinkedIn. "To our new teammates at Cognition: we at

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Windsurf feel incredibly lucky to be joining a team that shares our vision, our deep commitment to our users, and — most importantly — our values.”

Cognition says it’s acquiring Windsurf’s IP and product, which include its AI-powered IDE, alongside all of the employees who were not hired by Google.

Cognition did not announce the price it acquired Windsurf for; however, the company says Windsurf reached \$82 million in ARR, with enterprise ARR doubling quarter-over-quarter. Cognition says Windsurf’s user base reached at least 350 enterprise customers and “hundreds of thousands” of daily active users.

In the near term, Windsurf’s team will continue working on its AI-powered IDE, while Cognition works on its AI coding agent, Devin, the companies said in a press release. Eventually, Cognition says it will integrate Windsurf’s IP and capabilities into its own products.

TechCrunch reported in April that [Windsurf’s ARR had reached \\$100 million](#) at one point. However, Anthropic — which offers some of the most popular AI models for coding tasks — cut Windsurf’s direct access to its Claude AI models in June, with [Anthropic co-founder Jared Kaplan attributing the decision to rumors](#) that OpenAI, its largest competitor, was close to acquiring Windsurf. Several Windsurf customers told TechCrunch [they switched to other services that offered Claude AI models](#), such as Cursor, in light of the incident.

Cognition notes in its press release that Windsurf will now have full access to Claude AI models once again.

Over the weekend, The Information reported that Windsurf employees who had joined in the last year

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did not receive a payout in Google's billion-dollar reverse-acquihire. That prompted many users on social media to scoff at the deal, which seemed to largely benefit investors and leaders at the startup.

Cognition president Russell Kaplan indicated in a post on X that the Windsurf acquisition truly came together over the weekend, just hours after the Google deal was made public. He noted that the first call was made after 5 p.m. on Friday and that an agreement was signed Monday morning.



Russell Kaplan  
@russelljkaplan · [Follow](#)



Incredibly excited to share that Cognition is acquiring Windsurf. What an insane weekend - from first call after 5pm on Friday to a signed definitive agreement this morning. There's a lot to build!

 **Cognition**  @cognition

Cognition has signed a definitive agreement to acquire Windsurf.

The acquisition includes Windsurf's IP, product, trademark and brand, and strong business. Above all, it includes Windsurf's world-class people, whom we're privileged to welcome to our team.

We are also honoring



6:11 PM · Jul 14, 2025



550



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Cognition notes in its blog post that 100% of Windsurf employees will participate financially in this deal and have vesting cliffs waived for their work to date.

With the addition of Windsurf's talent and IP, Cognition may have a supercharged startup to compete with giants in the AI coding space, such as OpenAI, Anthropic, and Cursor. In March, Cognition reportedly held talks to [raise hundreds of millions of dollars at a \\$4 billion valuation](#). It's unclear if the round closed, but Cognition may need such a war chest to compete in the AI coding space.

Cognition was one of the first AI startups to launch a fully fledged AI coding agent, Devin, which didn't just help with tasks, but also promised to automate them completely as if it were a junior software engineer. This was a markedly bold approach compared to Cursor and Windsurf, which offered environments for developers to easily access AI tools. However, early reviews found that [Devin made mistakes](#), perhaps indicating that its AI agent technology was ahead of its time.

That may no longer be the case. In recent months, Cursor and Windsurf have started offering more agentic AI products that are starting to resemble what Cognition offers. In a recent interview, Cursor CEO Michael Truell said he [believes AI reasoning models are advancing enough to make coding agents viable](#) and that he expects 20% of coding workflows to be handled by agents by 2026.

Now Cognition has the versatility of offering both AI coding agents and an AI-powered IDE, perhaps enhancing its value proposition. Earlier this week, Cognition also landed a major customer in the [Wall Street juggernaut Goldman Sachs](#).

With the acquisition of Windsurf, it seems Cognition has become a more serious competitor in the AI coding space.

Update: A previous version of this article misstated what Windsurf's team will be doing at Cognition in the near term. This article was updated on July 14 to note that Windsurf's team will continue its normal work for now, and will eventually integrate its products into Cognition's offerings. We regret the error.

Topics: [AI](#) [ai coding](#) [cognition](#) [Windsurf](#)

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Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter | [X](#)

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

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Anthropic co-founder on cutting access to



Windsurf: ‘It would be odd for us to sell Claude to OpenAI’

Maxwell Zeff — 12:35 PM PDT · June 5, 2025

Anthropic co-founder and Chief Science Officer Jared Kaplan said his company cut Windsurf’s direct access to Anthropic’s Claude AI models largely because of rumors and reports that OpenAI, its largest competitor, is acquiring the AI coding assistant.

“We really are just trying to enable our customers who are going to sustainably be working with us in the future,” said Kaplan during an onstage interview Thursday with TechCrunch at [TC Sessions: AI 2025](#).
IMAGE CREDITS: ANTHONY F. CHURCH

“I think it would be odd for us to be selling Claude to OpenAI,” Kaplan said.

The comment comes just a few weeks after Bloomberg reported that [OpenAI was acquiring Windsurf for \\$3 billion](#). Earlier this week, Windsurf said that [Anthropic cut its direct access to Claude 3.5 Sonnet and Claude 3.7 Sonnet](#), two of the more popular AI models for coding, forcing the startup to find third-party computing providers on relatively short notice. Windsurf said it was disappointed in Anthropic’s decision and that it might cause short-term instability for users trying to access Claude via Windsurf.

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Windsurf declined to comment on Kaplan’s remarks, and an OpenAI spokesperson did not immediately respond to TechCrunch’s request. The companies have not confirmed the acquisition rumors.

Part of the reason Anthropic cut Windsurf’s access to Claude, according to Kaplan, is because the company is quite computing-constrained today. Anthropic would like to reserve its computing for what Kaplan characterized as “lasting partnerships.”

However, Kaplan said the company hopes to greatly increase the availability of models it can offer users and developers in the coming months. He added that Anthropic has just started to unlock capacity on a new computing cluster from its partner, Amazon, which he says is “really big and continues to scale.”

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As Anthropic pulls away from Windsurf, Kaplan said he's collaborating with other customers building AI coding tools, such as Cursor — a company Kaplan said Anthropic expects to work with for a long time. Kaplan rejected the idea that Anthropic was in competition with companies like Cursor, which is developing its own AI models.

Meanwhile, Kaplan says Anthropic is increasingly focused on developing its own agentic coding products, such as Claude Code, rather than AI chatbot experiences. While companies like OpenAI, Google, and Meta are competing for the most popular AI chatbot platform, Kaplan said the chatbot paradigm was limiting due to its static nature, and that AI agents would in the long run be much more helpful for users.

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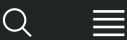


Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter | [X](#)

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch

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Vibe-coding startup Windsurf launches in-house AI models

Maxwell Zeff — 3:05 PM PDT · May 15, 2025

On Thursday, Windsurf, a startup that develops popular AI tools for software engineers, [announced](#) the launch of its first family of AI software engineering models, or SWE-1 for short. The startup says it trained its new family of AI models — SWE-1, SWE-1-lite, and SWE-1-mini — to be optimized for the “entire software engineering process,” not just coding.

The launch of Windsurf’s in-house AI models may come as a shock to some, given that OpenAI has reportedly [closed a \\$3 billion deal to acquire Windsurf](#). However, this model launch suggests Windsurf is trying to expand beyond just developing applications to also developing the models that power them.

[According to Windsurf](#), SWE-1, the largest and most capable AI model of the bunch, performs competitively with Claude 3.5 Sonnet, GPT-4.1, and Gemini 2.5 Pro on internal programming benchmarks. However, SWE-1 appears to fall short of frontier AI models, such as Claude 3.7 Sonnet, on software engineering tasks.

Windsurf says its SWE-1-lite and SWE-1-mini models will be available for all users on its platform, free or paid. Meanwhile, SWE-1 will only be available to paid users. Windsurf did not immediately announce pricing for its SWE-1 models but claims it’s cheaper to serve than Claude 3.5 Sonnet.

Windsurf is best known for tools that allow software engineers to write and edit code through conversations with an AI chatbot, a practice known as “vibe coding.” Other popular vibe-coding startups include Cursor, the largest in the space, as well as Lovable. Most of these startups, including Windsurf, have traditionally relied on AI models from OpenAI, Anthropic, and Google to power their applications.

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In a video announcing the SWE models, comments made by Windsurf’s Head of Research, Nicholas Moy, underscore Windsurf’s newest efforts to differentiate its approach. “Today’s frontier models are optimized for coding, and they’ve made massive strides over the last couple of years,” says Moy. “But they’re not enough for us ... Coding is not software engineering.”

Windsurf notes in a blog post that while other models are good at writing code, they struggle to work between multiple surfaces — as programmers often do — such as terminals, IDEs, and the internet. The startup says SWE-1 was trained using a new data model and a “training recipe that encapsulates incomplete states, long-running tasks, and multiple surfaces.”

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The startup describes SWE-1 as its “initial proof of concept,” suggesting it may release more AI models in the future.

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Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter |

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

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Three weeks after
acquiring Windsurf,

Cognition offers staff the exit door

Rebecca Bellan — 8:24 AM PDT · August 5, 2025

Cognition, the AI coding startup that acquired rival company Windsurf three weeks ago, laid off 30 employees last week and is offering buyouts to the roughly 200 remaining employees on the team, [reports The Information](#)

This is the latest bout of whiplash that Windsurf employees have faced after a tumultuous stretch for the company. The startup was initially almost acquired by OpenAI, then lost its [CEO, co-founder, and research leads to Google](#) in a \$2.4 billion deal known as a reverse-acqui-hire (where Google hired the key talent rather than buying the company), before ultimately getting [acquired by Cognition](#).

IMAGE CREDITS: COGNITION

At the time of the acquisition, Cognition stated that 100% of Windsurf employees would receive financial compensation as part of the deal and [stressed](#) that the company was excited to bring on Windsurf's "world-class people" to develop top-notch coding tools.

Now, it's becoming clear that Windsurf's intellectual property, not its talent, was the real buy.

According to an email The Information viewed, employees were given until August 10 to decide whether they want to take the buyout, which amounts to nine months of salary. Those who

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choose to stay are reportedly required to spend six days at the office and clock more than 80-hour weeks — draconian conditions that have become [table stakes among workers at top AI firms](#).

“We don’t believe in work-life balance—building the future of software engineering is a mission we all care so deeply about that we couldn’t possibly separate the two,” wrote Cognition CEO Scott Wu in the email.

TechCrunch has reached out to Cognition for more details.

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Rebecca Bellan

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Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, where she covers Tesla and Elon Musk's broader empire,...

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